VENVLEARNING

STUDENT TEXTBOOK



Social Studies

GRADE 4

Lessons, examples, and practice for the whole year

2026–2027 School Year · Unit 1: Mississippi: Land and Regions

VENVLEARNING

Grade 4
Social Studies

STUDENT TEXTBOOK

2026–2027 School Year

Unit 1 Mississippi: Land and Regions

This book belongs to _____

A VenvLearning family homeschool curriculum

How to use this book

Each lesson starts with an I can goal and a Think About It question. Read the lesson with your teacher. Read the Look Closer boxes to see how a historian or geographer reads a source, map, or chart, and answer the Check Your Understanding questions. Your practice pages are in your Student Workbook, labeled with the same lesson number.

- Key Idea boxes hold the most important rule or fact. Learn these.
- Watch Out boxes warn you about common mistakes.
- Activity boxes are hands-on map, source, and timeline work. Do them with your teacher.
- Every Friday there is a short Weekly Check in your workbook. The last Friday of a unit is the Unit Test.

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UNIT 1

Mississippi: Land and Regions

Map skills, location, landforms and rivers, natural regions, resources, and regional economies.

From the flat, fertile Delta to the pine forests and the Gulf Coast, Mississippi is a state of many landscapes. In this unit you'll learn to read maps like a geographer, find Mississippi's place in the world, explore its rivers and regions, and discover how its natural resources shape the way people live and work.

In this unit you will…

- Read maps using the title, compass rose, key, and scale.
- Describe Mississippi's relative and absolute location.
- Identify landforms, waterways, and natural regions.
- Classify natural resources and explain how they shape regional economies.

CONNECTIONS TODAY

Pilots, truck drivers, farmers, and city planners all depend on maps and on knowing what each region's land can do.

UNIT VOCABULARY

compass rose	Shows directions on a map.
latitude	Lines measuring distance north or south of the equator.
region	An area with shared features.
natural resource	Something from nature people use.
goods	Things made or grown to sell.
services	Work done for others.

Lessons in this unit

Lesson	Title
1.1	Maps and Globes

Lesson	Title
1.2	Where in the World Is Mississippi?
1.3	Mississippi's Land and Water
1.4	Reading Physical and Political Maps
1.5	Mississippi's Natural Regions
1.6	Comparing the Delta and the Piney Woods
1.7	Natural Resources
1.8	Resources and Work in Each Region

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.1 · C3 D2.Geo.1.3-5

Lesson 1.1: Maps and Globes

I can use a map's title, compass rose, key, and scale to read a map.

WORDS TO KNOW

globe	A model of Earth shaped like a ball.
compass rose	A symbol that shows directions on a map.
map key	A box that explains the symbols on a map (also called a legend).
map scale	A line that shows how distance on the map compares with real distance.

THINK ABOUT IT

If you had to give a friend directions from your house to a park, what would you draw?

A globe is a model of Earth, so it shows shapes and distances correctly, but it's hard to carry and you can only see half at a time. A map is a flat drawing of a place. Maps can show a whole country or one small neighborhood.

Map part	What it tells you
title	what the map shows
compass rose	directions: north (N), south (S), east (E), west (W), and in-between directions like northeast (NE)
map key (legend)	what each symbol, line, or color means
scale	how far apart places really are

This map's title tells you it shows cities of Mississippi. The star marks Jackson, the state capital, and dots mark other cities.

The compass rose in the top corner points north. The scale bar at the bottom stands for 50 miles. Rivers are drawn in blue.

Notice that the Mississippi River traces most of the state's western edge, and the southern coast meets the Gulf of Mexico.

Cities of Mississippi



LOOK CLOSER · USE THE SCALE

About how far is it from Jackson to Gulfport?

1 Measure the distance on the map with a strip of paper.

2 Compare it with the scale bar (50 miles).

3 The distance is about three scale bars long.

Answer: about 150 miles

ACTIVITY · MAP MY ROOM

Can you make a map someone else could use?

You need: paper; ruler; colored pencils.

1 Draw your bedroom or kitchen as if you were looking down from the ceiling.

2 Add a title and a compass rose (find north with a compass app or the sunrise in the east).

3 Make a key with at least four symbols.

4 Add a scale such as “1 inch = 2 feet.”

Record: your finished map; trade with a family member and ask them to find something using only the map.

KEY IDEA

Read the title, check the compass rose, use the key, and measure with the scale.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answer in your notebook in complete sentences. Then check with your teacher.

1. Which map part explains symbols?
2. Which direction is between north and east?
3. Which city is the state capital?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.1.

LESSON SUMMARY

Title, compass rose, key, and scale help you read any map.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.2 · C3 D2.Geo.2.3-5

Lesson 1.2: Where in the World Is Mississippi?

I can describe Mississippi's location using relative location, hemispheres, and latitude and longitude.

WORDS TO KNOW

relative location	Where a place is compared with other places.
absolute location	The exact location of a place, given by latitude and longitude.
latitude	Imaginary lines that run east and west and measure distance north or south of the equator.
longitude	Imaginary lines that run north and south and measure distance east or west of the prime meridian.
hemisphere	Half of Earth.

THINK ABOUT IT

How would you describe where you live to someone on the other side of the world?

Relative location describes a place by what is near it. Mississippi is in the southern United States. It borders Tennessee to the north, Alabama to the east, the Gulf of Mexico and Louisiana to the south, and Louisiana and Arkansas to the west, across the Mississippi River.



Mississippi is highlighted.

Absolute location uses a grid of imaginary lines. Lines of latitude measure degrees north or south of the equator. Lines of longitude measure degrees east or west of the prime meridian.

Because Mississippi is north of the equator and west of the prime meridian, it is in the Northern and Western Hemispheres. Jackson is at about 32° N, 90° W.



Latitude labels at left; longitude labels at bottom.

ACTIVITY · GRID HUNT

Can you find places using latitude and longitude?

You need: a globe or world map with latitude and longitude lines; notebook.

1 Find 30° N, 90° W. What place is near there?

2 Find the equator and the prime meridian.

3 Find a place in each of the four hemispheres.

4 Make up two coordinates and challenge a family member to find them.

Record: each coordinate and the place you found.

KEY IDEA

Relative location compares places; absolute location uses latitude and longitude. Mississippi is in the Northern and Western Hemispheres.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answer in your notebook in complete sentences. Then check with your teacher.

1. Which state borders Mississippi to the east?
2. Which body of water is south of Mississippi?
3. Which hemispheres is Mississippi in?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.2.

LESSON SUMMARY

Mississippi is in the southern U.S., in the Northern and Western Hemispheres, around 32° N, 90° W.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.3 · C3 D2.Geo.2.3-5

Lesson 1.3: Mississippi's Land and Water

I can identify Mississippi's major landforms and waterways and explain why they matter.

WORDS TO KNOW

landform	A natural shape of the land, such as a hill, plain, or valley.
plain	A large area of flat land.
river basin	All the land drained by a river and the streams that flow into it.
bluff	A high, steep bank, often along a river.
tributary	A smaller river or stream that flows into a larger one.

THINK ABOUT IT

Most of Mississippi's rivers flow toward the south. Why do you think that is?

Mississippi is mostly low, rolling hills and flat plains. Its highest point is Woodall Mountain in the far northeast, about 806 feet above sea level. Its lowest point is sea level along the Gulf of Mexico. Because the land is generally higher in the north and lower in the south, most rivers flow

south toward the Gulf.

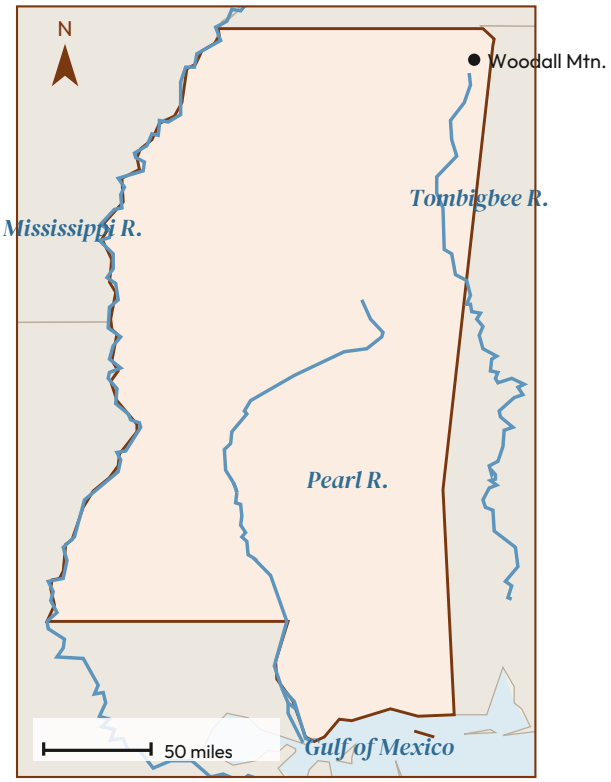
Waterway	Fact
Mississippi River	Forms most of the state's western border; one of the longest rivers in North America
Yazoo River	Flows through the Delta into the Mississippi at Vicksburg
Pearl River	Flows past Jackson to the Gulf; part of it forms the border with Louisiana
Tombigbee River	Flows south through eastern Mississippi into Alabama
Pascagoula River	Flows into the Gulf at Pascagoula
Gulf of Mexico	Mississippi's southern coast, about 44 miles long

Waterways have always mattered to people here. Rivers provided fish, water, and travel routes for American Indian nations.

Later, steamboats carried cotton and goods on the Mississippi River.

Today, barges still move goods on the Mississippi and on the Tennessee-Tombigbee Waterway, a canal system opened in 1985 that connects the Tennessee River to the Tombigbee.

Major rivers



ACTIVITY · WHICH WAY DOES WATER FLOW?

How does the slope of land decide where rivers go?

You need: a baking sheet or tray; a towel to tilt it; a cup of water; a few pebbles.

1 Raise one end of the tray to make “high land” in the north.

2 Slowly pour water at the high end.

3 Watch which way it flows and where it collects.

4 Add pebbles as “hills” and observe how the water's path changes.

Record: a sketch showing high land, low land, and the water's path, and an explanation linked to Mississippi's rivers.

KEY IDEA

Mississippi's land is higher in the north and lower in the south, so most rivers flow south to the Gulf. Rivers have shaped travel, trade, and settlement.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answer in your notebook in complete sentences. Then check with your teacher.

1. What is Mississippi's highest point?
2. Which river forms most of the western border?
3. Why do most rivers flow south?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.3.

LESSON SUMMARY

Most Mississippi rivers flow south to the Gulf; waterways shape travel and trade.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.4 · C3 D2.Geo.1.3-5

Lesson 1.4: Reading Physical and Political Maps

I can tell physical and political maps apart and use each to answer questions.

WORDS TO KNOW

physical map	A map that shows natural features such as rivers, mountains, and elevation.
political map	A map that shows human-made boundaries, states, counties, and cities.
elevation	How high land is above sea level.
county	One of the parts a state is divided into for local government.

THINK ABOUT IT

What's the difference between a map of the rivers in Mississippi and a map of its cities?

A physical map shows what nature made: rivers, hills, coastlines, and elevation, often with colors (green for low land, tan or brown for higher land). A political map shows what people decided: state and county boundaries, capitals, and cities. Mississippi is divided into 82 counties.

Question	Better map
Where is the state capital?	political
Where is the land highest?	physical
Which county is Tupelo in?	political
Which way does the Pearl River flow?	physical

LOOK CLOSER · USE TWO MAPS TOGETHER

Why did cities like Vicksburg and Natchez grow where they did?

1 Physical map: both sit on high bluffs beside the Mississippi River.

2 Political map: both are cities in western Mississippi.

3 Put them together: the high bluffs were safe from floods, and the river brought trade.

Answer: They grew on bluffs above the river, where people could trade by boat but stay above floodwaters.

ACTIVITY · SALT DOUGH RELIEF MAP

Can you build a physical map of Mississippi?

You need: outline of Mississippi traced on cardboard; salt dough (2 cups flour, 1 cup salt, about 3/4 cup water); paint; toothpick flags.

1. Spread a thin layer of dough over the outline.
2. Build it a little higher in the northeast and keep the Delta and coast flat.
3. Press a groove for the Mississippi and Pearl rivers.
4. When dry, paint low land green and higher land tan, and add flags for Jackson and your town.

Record: a photo or sketch of your map with a key.

KEY IDEA

Physical maps show natural features; political maps show boundaries and cities. Using both explains why places are where they are.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answer in your notebook in complete sentences. Then check with your teacher.

1. Which kind of map shows county lines?
2. Which kind shows elevation?
3. How many counties does Mississippi have?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.4.

LESSON SUMMARY

Physical maps show nature; political maps show boundaries and cities.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.5 · C3 D2.Geo.2.3-5

Lesson 1.5: Mississippi's Natural Regions

I can identify Mississippi's natural regions and describe the land in each.

WORDS TO KNOW

region	An area with features that make it different from other areas.
fertile	Able to grow many plants; rich soil.
alluvial	Made of soil left behind by rivers.

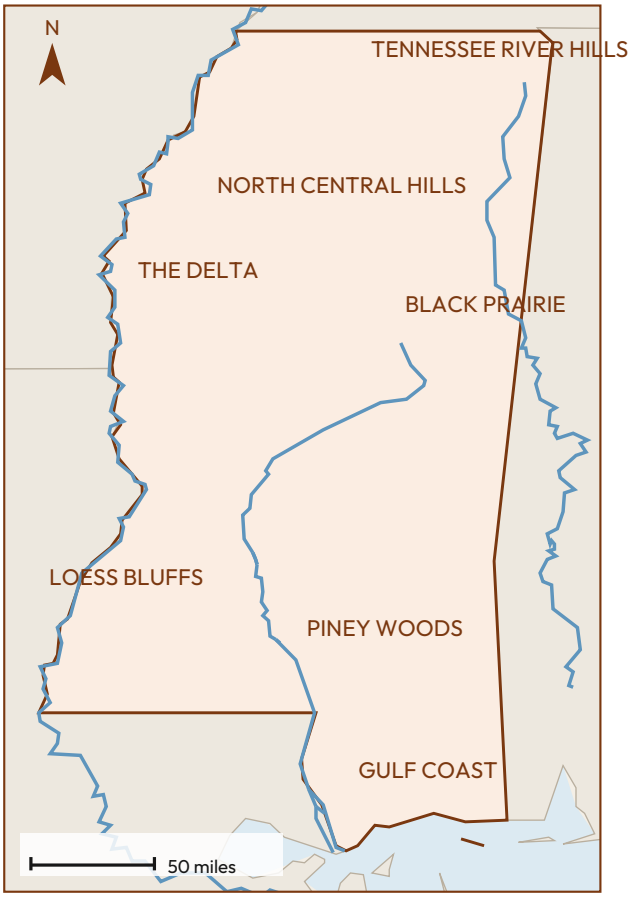
THINK ABOUT IT

If you drove from Tupelo to Greenville to Gulfport, how might the land outside your window change?

Geographers divide Mississippi into natural regions by land, soil, and plants.

Regions don't have sharp edges; one blends into the next. The labels on the map show where each region generally is.

As you read the chart below, find each region on the map.



General locations of Mississippi's natural regions.

Region	What the land is like
The Delta	very flat, fertile alluvial soil left by Mississippi and Yazoo river floods; northwest
Loess Bluffs	steep bluffs of fine wind-blown soil along the east edge of the Mississippi River valley
North Central Hills	rolling hills with red clay soil
Tennessee River Hills	the highest, most rugged land, in the far northeast
Black Prairie	gently rolling land with dark, rich soil in the northeast
Piney Woods	rolling hills with sandy soil and pine forests in the south
Gulf Coast	low, flat land with beaches, marshes, and bays along the Gulf of Mexico

ACTIVITY · REGION POSTCARDS

What would you see in each region?

You need: index cards; colored pencils.

1 Choose three regions.

2 On each card, draw a scene showing the land, plants, and one way people use the land.

3 On the back, write a short message describing the region to a friend.

Record: three postcards with accurate details.

KEY IDEA

Mississippi's regions include the Delta, Loess Bluffs, the hills, the Black Prairie, the Piney Woods, and the Gulf Coast, each with its own land and soil.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answer in your notebook in complete sentences. Then check with your teacher.

1. Which region is flattest and most fertile?
2. Which region has pine forests?
3. Which region has the highest land?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.5.

LESSON SUMMARY

Each region of Mississippi has its own land, soil, and plants.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.6 · C3 D2.Geo.4.3-5

Lesson 1.6: Comparing the Delta and the Piney Woods

I can compare two regions and explain how land affects the way people live and work.

WORDS TO KNOW

compare	To tell how things are alike.
contrast	To tell how things are different.
timber	Trees cut for wood and wood products.

THINK ABOUT IT

How might growing up on a Delta farm be different from growing up in a Piney Woods town?

The Delta is a broad, flat plain in northwestern Mississippi between the Mississippi and Yazoo rivers. For thousands of years, floods left layers of rich soil. Today the Delta is known for large farms of cotton, soybeans, corn, and rice, and for catfish farming in ponds. Towns are spread out across wide fields. The Delta is also famous as a birthplace of the blues.

The Piney Woods covers much of southeastern Mississippi. Its sandy soil is less fertile for crops, but it is excellent for growing pine trees. Lumber and paper mills grew up around cities such as Hattiesburg and Laurel. Forests here also support hunting, outdoor recreation, and wildlife.

	The Delta	Piney Woods	Both
land	very flat	rolling hills	part of Mississippi; rivers
soil	rich alluvial soil	sandy soil	
main uses	row crops, catfish farms	timber, paper, outdoor recreation	agriculture is important
places	Greenville, Clarksdale	Hattiesburg, Laurel	

ACTIVITY · VENN DIAGRAM

How are the two regions alike and different?

You need: paper; two colored pencils.

1 Draw two overlapping circles labeled Delta and Piney Woods.

2 Write at least four details in each outer part.

3 Write at least two shared details in the middle.

4 Write a summary sentence.

Record: your Venn diagram and summary.

KEY IDEA

The land and soil of a region shape how people earn a living there.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answer in your notebook in complete sentences. Then check with your teacher.

1. Why is the Delta good for crops?
2. What grows well in the Piney Woods?
3. Name a Piney Woods city.

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.6.

LESSON SUMMARY

The Delta's rich soil supports crops; the Piney Woods' sandy soil supports forests.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.7 · C3 D2.Eco.3.3-5

Lesson 1.7: Natural Resources

I can identify Mississippi's natural resources and classify them as renewable or nonrenewable.

WORDS TO KNOW

natural resource	Something from nature that people use.
renewable resource	A resource that can be replaced naturally or by people in a reasonable time.
nonrenewable resource	A resource that cannot be replaced once it is used up, or takes millions of years to form.
conservation	Careful use and protection of resources.

THINK ABOUT IT

Look around the room. What came from nature: from soil, trees, water, or underground?

Mississippi is rich in natural resources. Some are renewable: forests can be replanted, and fish and farm crops can grow again if they are managed well. Others are nonrenewable: oil and natural gas, found underground in parts of southern Mississippi and offshore in the Gulf, took millions of years to form.

Resource	Renewable?	Used for
fertile soil	renewable if cared for	growing crops
forests	renewable (replanting)	lumber, paper, furniture
water (rivers, groundwater)	renewable	drinking, farming, fishing, transportation
fish and shellfish (Gulf)	renewable if not overfished	food
oil and natural gas	nonrenewable	fuel, energy
sand, gravel, and clay	nonrenewable	building roads and bricks

Conservation helps resources last. Foresters replant trees after harvests, farmers protect soil from erosion, and fishing seasons and limits help keep Gulf fish and shrimp populations healthy.

ACTIVITY · RESOURCE HUNT

Where do the things in your home come from?

You need: notebook.

1. Find ten objects in your home.
2. For each, name the natural resource it came from (wood, cotton, oil/plastic, metal, sand/glass).
3. Label each resource renewable or nonrenewable.
4. Circle one item you could reuse or recycle.

Record: a three-column chart: Object | Natural resource | Renewable or nonrenewable.

KEY IDEA

Natural resources come from nature. Renewable resources can be replaced; nonrenewable ones cannot. Conservation helps them last.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answer in your notebook in complete sentences. Then check with your teacher.

1. Is a pine forest renewable or nonrenewable?
2. Is natural gas renewable?
3. Name one way to conserve a resource.

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.7.

LESSON SUMMARY

Renewable resources can be replaced; nonrenewable ones cannot; conservation helps both.

UNIT 1 · LESSON 1.8 · C3 D2.Eco.3.3-5, D2.Geo.4.3-5

Lesson 1.8: Resources and Work in Each Region

I can explain how natural resources shape the goods, services, and jobs in different regions.

WORDS TO KNOW

goods	Things people make or grow to sell.
services	Work people do for others.
economy	The way people make, buy, sell, and use goods and services.
producer	A person or business that makes goods or provides services.

THINK ABOUT IT

A Delta farmer, a Piney Woods mill worker, and a Gulf Coast shrimper all earn a living. What does each one depend on?

The economy of each region grows from its resources. Farmers grow goods in fertile soil. Mill workers turn trees into lumber and paper. Gulf Coast workers catch seafood, build ships, and serve visitors. Agriculture is Mississippi's largest industry, and chickens raised for meat (broilers) are among its most valuable farm products.

Region	Key resources	Goods and services
The Delta	rich soil, water	cotton, soybeans, rice, corn, farm-raised catfish
Piney Woods	pine forests	lumber, paper, wood products
Black Prairie and hills	soil, pasture	cattle, poultry, crops, manufacturing
Gulf Coast	the Gulf, beaches, ports	seafood, shipbuilding, shipping, tourism

LOOK CLOSER · TRACE A PRODUCT

A pine tree becomes a notebook

1. Natural resource: a pine tree grows in the Piney Woods.
2. Producers: loggers harvest it; a paper mill turns it into paper.
3. Services: truck drivers deliver it; a store sells it.
4. Consumer: you buy the notebook.

Answer: One resource creates many jobs on its way to you.

ACTIVITY · REGIONAL ECONOMY POSTER

How does one region earn a living?

You need: poster paper; markers.

1 Choose one region.

2 Show its resources, two goods or services, and two jobs.

3 Draw arrows from each resource to the goods it produces.

4 Present your poster to your family.

Record: your poster and a two-sentence summary.

KEY IDEA

Natural resources shape the goods, services, and jobs in each region.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

Answer in your notebook in complete sentences. Then check with your teacher.

1. Goods or service: a haircut

2. Goods or service: a bag of rice

3. Which region is known for shipbuilding and seafood?

More practice: Workbook, Lesson 1.8.

LESSON SUMMARY

Each region's resources shape its goods, services, and jobs.

UNIT 1 REVIEW

Unit 1 Study Guide

Use this page to get ready for the unit test. Read each big idea, then try the review pages in your workbook.

Lesson	Remember…
1.1	Title, compass rose, key, and scale help you read any map.
1.2	Mississippi is in the southern U.S., in the Northern and Western Hemispheres, around 32° N, 90° W.
1.3	Most Mississippi rivers flow south to the Gulf; waterways shape travel and trade.
1.4	Physical maps show nature; political maps show boundaries and cities.
1.5	Each region of Mississippi has its own land, soil, and plants.
1.6	The Delta's rich soil supports crops; the Piney Woods' sandy soil supports forests.
1.7	Renewable resources can be replaced; nonrenewable ones cannot; conservation helps both.
1.8	Each region's resources shape its goods, services, and jobs.

Glossary

absolute location	The exact location of a place, given by latitude and longitude.
alluvial	Made of soil left behind by rivers.
bluff	A high, steep bank, often along a river.
compare	To tell how things are alike.
compass rose	Shows directions on a map.
conservation	Careful use and protection of resources.
contrast	To tell how things are different.
county	One of the parts a state is divided into for local government.
economy	The way people make, buy, sell, and use goods and services.
elevation	How high land is above sea level.
fertile	Able to grow many plants; rich soil.
globe	A model of Earth shaped like a ball.
goods	Things made or grown to sell.
hemisphere	Half of Earth.
landform	A natural shape of the land, such as a hill, plain, or valley.
latitude	Lines measuring distance north or south of the equator.
longitude	Imaginary lines that run north and south and measure distance east or west of the prime meridian.
map key	A box that explains the symbols on a map (also called a legend).
map scale	A line that shows how distance on the map compares with real distance.
natural resource	Something from nature people use.
nonrenewable resource	A resource that cannot be replaced once it is used up, or takes millions of years to form.
physical map	A map that shows natural features such as rivers, mountains, and elevation.
plain	A large area of flat land.
political map	A map that shows human-made boundaries, states, counties, and cities.
producer	A person or business that makes goods or provides services.
region	An area with shared features.
relative location	Where a place is compared with other places.

renewable resource	A resource that can be replaced naturally or by people in a reasonable time.
river basin	All the land drained by a river and the streams that flow into it.
services	Work done for others.
timber	Trees cut for wood and wood products.
tributary	A smaller river or stream that flows into a larger one.

Grade 4 Social Studies

Student Textbook · 2026–2027

A full year of Grade 4 social studies. Students read maps, weigh primary and secondary sources, build timelines, and connect geography, history, government, and economics to the people and places that shaped our world.

This Student Textbook teaches every lesson: the big idea, key vocabulary, models and examples, and a short set of practice problems to check understanding. It pairs with the Student Workbook and the Teacher Edition.

INSIDE THIS YEAR

01 Mississippi: Land and Regions

IN THIS BOOK

- Clear lesson goals: “I can…” statements
- Key vocabulary with student-friendly definitions
- Models, examples, and Key Idea summaries
- A study guide and glossary for every unit

THE COMPLETE SET



Textbook
You are holding this book

Workbook

Teacher Edition

Each lesson has the same number in all three books, and every day of the year is mapped to its lesson in the VenvLearning planner.